

Working the Google Project Oxygen Case

Module 3, Part 2 (October 17)

QBA 5330

The Case, Restated

Google's people analytics team compared managers in the **top and bottom quartiles** of a combined survey-and-performance-review score.

They compared those managers' teams on **satisfaction, retention, and performance**.

This is an **observational** comparison, not a randomized experiment.

Team Worksheet

Same worksheet for every team, 40 minutes.

1. Random assignment
2. Confounders (find a **new** one)
3. Bias in how “high/low-scoring” was defined
4. Statistical vs. practical significance
5. A **specific, concrete** stronger design
6. Your team’s verdict

1. Random Assignment

Was there random assignment in this study?

What would a **randomized version** of this study look like in practice?

2. Confounders

The reading already named team quality/resources and reverse causation.

Find at least one more.

3. Bias

“High-scoring” and “low-scoring” managers were defined by a combination of upward-feedback survey scores and performance reviews.

What kind of bias could this introduce?

4. Statistical vs. Practical Significance

The differences are described as reliable, but sometimes small.

What additional information would you want before rolling this out company-wide?

5. A Stronger Design

Propose a **specific** design. Not “do an experiment.”

- Who gets randomly assigned to what?
- What’s the treatment?
- What do you measure, and on whom?

6. Your Team's Verdict

In one or two sentences:

Does the evidence support “managers matter”? What’s your strongest reason?

Before the Break

Choose a spokesperson.

Be ready to share your team's answer to **one** worksheet item in Part 3.